recommended that rice, dal, ghee, papads, and vegetables be served along with the meats and as for the vegetables, the author Ksemasarma seems to have brazenly favoured aubergines over all others and to have been very particular in their preparation, for he says: ‘Fie on the meal that has no aubergine. Fie on the aubergine that has no stalk. Fie on the aubergine that has a stalk but is not cooked in oil and fie upon the aubergine that is cooked in oil without using asafoetida!’ For eighteen days the music, the women’s laughter, the swirling skirts of the dancers, the hoarse singing of the yogis, tumbled out from the courtyards of Fatehpur Sikri into the bazaars below and such celebrations, it was whispered, had not been seen in thirty years.

For Akbar, at the dawn of his fortieth birthday, this was a glittering moment. He had won a great victory, not only against Mirza Hakim but against all those who had used the mirza as ballast for their claims of heresy against the Padshah. After three years of intense turbulence, both within the ibadat khana and on the battlefields, Akbar had forced a reckoning. Opposition to his supremacy had been categorically quelled, both in the borderlands of his kingdom and in the order of theologians who had challenged him. The Jesuit priests themselves marvelled that there had been no one since Timur who had won so many battles and conquered so great an area. Starting with his subduing of Bairam Khan and the control of Delhi twenty-five years previously, Akbar had gone on to conquer Malwa, Gondwana, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Bihar, Bengal, Kabul, and would soon annex Kashmir and the Sind. All that would remain, they surmised, was the Deccan.

Now Akbar was free to formulate a more capacious world view, one which would reflect with greater accuracy the teeming clans of noblemen who made up the Mughal court, each with their own truths and divinities. For the astrologers who kept a close watch on the stars, this was a moment charged with significance because the two superior planets, Saturn and Jupiter, were in conjunction, which was as rare as it was powerful. It had occurred at the birth of Timur, and at the birth of the Prophet Muhammad. Now after a thousand years had passed, the planets were aligning themselves again, to announce the coming of the second Islamic millennium with all its possibility of renewal and rebirth.

If the celebrations of the new year were resplendent, there was also a parallel enthusiasm for change and new beginnings. One of the first decisions that Akbar took in this year was the liberating of his own slaves.